

Session 6: Confronting the Firstborn

Key Takeaways

- Moses' return to Egypt in [Exodus 4:18-31](#) is a tightly constructed literary unit that creates the first part of a frame to Israel's deliverance story.
- Zipporah's intervention delivers Moses' life. This carries forward the theme of women delivering the deliverer.
- Moses' identity as a covenant member is solidified in this story. He could not lead Israel in obedience to Yahweh when he was not compliant to Yahweh's instructions himself.

Textual Unity

[Exodus 4:18-31](#) is a tightly constructed literary unit with an important literary function.

- Mention of the *htn*, or relative by marriage ([4:18](#); [4:25-26](#))
- Commission of Moses and Aaron ([4:19](#); [4:27](#))
- Firstborn of YHWH and Pharaoh ([4:22-23](#))
- Pharaoh and YHWH sought to kill Moses ([4:19](#); [4:24](#))
- YHWH would kill Pharaoh's son and Moses' son ([4:23-24](#))
- YHWH's and Aaron's encounter (פגש) with Moses ([4:24](#); [4:27](#))
- Moses' intention to see his brothers and Moses and Aaron's arrival in Egypt ([4:18](#); [4:27-31](#))

Literary Function

- The conversation with Jethro frames Israel's deliverance story ([Exod. 4:18](#); [18:7](#)).
- The women delivering Moses frame Moses' deliverance story ([1-2](#); [4:24-26](#)).
 - Zipporah (צפורה) sounds like Shiprah (שפרה) in Hebrew.
- Circumcision anticipates Passover ([4:24-26](#); [12:8](#), [12-13](#)).
 - Both rituals protect from YHWH killing the firstborn.
 - In both rituals, blood is applied by "touching" (נגע; [4:25](#); [12:13](#), [22-23](#)).

"Once again it is a woman who, by her quick-wittedness and insight, saves Moses. [Zipporah] stands in the train of the midwives, Moses' mother and sister, and the daughter of Pharaoh. Moses owes his very life to a series of actions by women, two of them non-Israelites. ... Moses is thus revealed as one who does not himself stand without need of mediation with God."

Fretheim, Terence (2010). [Exodus \(Interpretation: A Bible Commentary for Teaching and Preaching\)](#). Westminster John Knox Press. 80-81.

Theological Function

Moses’ near-death experience sounds like Jacob’s and like Balaam’s.

Genesis 32: Jacob	Exodus 4: Moses	Numbers 22: Balaam
Left father-in-law	Left father-in-law	
Journeyed to meet brother with wives and sons	Journeyed to meet brother with wife and sons <i>on donkey</i>	Journeyed to the Israelites <i>on a donkey</i>
Encountered God where he spent the night with an uncertain reception	Encountered God (<i>angry</i>) where he spent the night with an uncertain reception	Encountered God (<i>angry</i>) with an uncertain reception
Left with his staff	Took his staff	Took his staff
Spared by the angel who spoke to him	Saved by his wife who spoke to him	Saved by his donkey who spoke to him
Left encounter injured	Left encounter injured and with bloodied “feet”	Left encounter injured with a crushed foot
Met and kissed his brother	Met and kissed his brother	
Theological Function of Exodus 4:24-25. Created by Carmen Imes for BibleProject Classroom: Exodus Overview (2021).		

An Enigmatic Scene

Moses’ encounter with God on the way back to Egypt is filled with ambiguities and raises many questions.

- Who is YHWH trying to kill, Moses or Gershom?
- Why would YHWH try to kill Moses right after commissioning him?
- Why is Moses entirely passive in this story?
- Why had Moses not already circumcised his son?
- Was Moses already circumcised?
- How did Zipporah know what to do?
- Whose “feet” does Zipporah touch with the foreskin? Her son’s? Moses’? YHWH’s?
- Is this a reference to actual feet or a euphemism for male genitalia (cf. [Deut. 28:57](#); [Isa. 6:2](#), [7:20](#))?
- Who drew back from whom after she performed the ritual?
- What does her statement mean?

Unlocking the Enigma

Zipporah's statement: "you are a blood relative" (חתן-דמים אתה לי) uses the same root *hṭn* that means "father-in-law" in 4:18. The basic meaning is kinship by marriage. In his article, "'Lest Ye Perish in the Way': Ritual and Kinship in Exodus 4:24-26," Christopher Hays argues, "through this ritual, Zipporah claims her family's relationship to the Divine Kinsman, YHWH" (Hays, 2017).

No matter who Zipporah circumcised, whose "feet" she touched, and to whom she spoke, her ritual action and statement resolved the uncertainty of their covenant status. YHWH announced his intention to kill the firstborn of Egypt; now Moses' family is fully identified with the descendants of Abraham.

Circumcision

Circumcision is the incision or complete removal of the foreskin, and in the Bible it is the sign of God's covenant with Abraham (Gen. 17:9-14). Other cultures practiced circumcision at puberty or marriage, but the Israelites performed it on the eighth day after birth for every male community member, even foreigners (Exod. 12:48).

Circumcision was not practiced on the wilderness generation (see Josh. 5:5)! God's people had failed to circumcise their sons on the way and died in the wilderness. Joshua rectified their oversight by acting as Zipporah had done, circumcising the "sons of Israel" with flint knives to ensure their covenant status.

Reflection Question

Do you still have any questions about the enigmatic scene in Exodus 4:24-25?